



July 2026
50th Year of Growth
1976 - 2026



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The DGC committee meeting was held on 1st July 2026 at 7.30 pm.
The next DGC meeting will be held on **Wednesday, 8 July 2026**
7.30 pm at the RSL Hall , cnr Doncaster Road and Leeds Street. Doors open at 7.15pm

The speaker is Bruno Tigani - Commercial Vegetable Seed Industry
Bruno will be bringing seedlings to sell!

Committee Members 2026

President
Avril Clark
0402 478 302
doncastergardenclubinc@gmail.com

Vice-President & Speaker Bookings:
Vacant

Treasurer:
Dr Margaret Salter

Secretary:
Virgina Roberts & Connie Lee
secretary@doncastergardenclubaus.com

Fund Raising Co-Ordinator:
Anita Lizza

Newsletter:
Rohini Padey
newseditor@doncastergardenclubaus.com

Reinhard
Esther Sim

Ray Brett

President's Message - July 2026

Vale Toni Myers

It is with great sadness that we announce the passing of Life Member Toni Myers. Toni, although not a foundation member, has spent decades dedicated to serving the Doncaster Garden Club. She has served on the Committee in several capacities and has always been happy to help when needed.

We, as a Club, honour her loyalty and devotion and her willingness to do anything that was needed as well as her knowledge and practical experience that she brought to the Club.

In August we will be bulk ordering good quality manure. Please think about your needs ready for when we order. We will let you know prices, quantities etc very shortly. Also next month ,August, we will be having a Q and A on preparing your garden for spring planting. Please have your questions ready for this event.

Please make sure that Saturday 3rd October is in your calendar so that we can celebrate 50 years of the Doncaster Garden Club together.

Avril

Doncaster Garden Club Subscriptions are due for renewal by the 31st October 2026

Please bring your returnable bottles and cans each month so we can collect the 10c deposit to add to the DGC financial reserve. (No squashed cans please)

Speaker for June - Rachel Maggiore - Pruning roses



We recently welcomed Rachel Maggiore, a new garden club member, qualified horticulturalist, and owner of Seed Sensations Gardening Services, who facilitated a relaxed and practical session on rose pruning.

Rachel took us through the basics including the big message: don't be afraid to prune. Roses are tougher than they look, and even a simple prune will set them up for better growth and more flowers.

Always remove the "3 Ds": dead, damaged and diseased wood. From there, aim for an open, vase-like shape by cutting just above outward-facing buds and removing any crossing branches.

Rachel went through a number of different rose varieties and how to prune them, including the exception to the rule of "Prune in Winter" with rambling roses needing to be pruned after flowering in Summer/Autumn as they flower on old wood. Rachel also highlighted how to spot and remove suckers (pull them out from the base, don't cut them) and reminded us not to forget the follow-up care—clean up, feed, mulch and water to support strong new growth. Rachel supported all of this information with a live demonstration, pruning a standard iceberg rose and also shared two short videos to help bring this all together.

Most importantly, give it a go. As Rachel reminded us, roses are forgiving—and they'll reward your efforts.

Upcoming Calendar Events:

Upcoming Committee Meeting:	01 July	hosted by Avril Clark, 7.30pm at 62 Pine Hill Drive Doncaster East
Upcoming Meeting:	08 July	at the RSL Hall, 7.30pm at cnr Doncaster Road and Leeds Street Doncaster East

Following Committee Meeting:	05 August	hosted by Avril Clark, 7.30pm at 62 Pine Hill Drive Doncaster East
Following Meeting:	12 August	at the RSL Hall, 7.30pm at cnr Doncaster Road and Leeds Street Doncaster East

Speaker at the August meeting:
Club Q & A and Preparing your garden for spring vegetables

How to use Feverfew to Manage Aphids in your Garden

Companion Planting: Plant feverfew near vegetables and rose bushes to naturally deter aphids, whiteflies, and spider mites.

Attract Predators: Let the flowers bloom to attract hoverflies and ladybirds, which are natural aphid predators.

Feverfew Tea Spray: Steep crushed fresh leaves and flowers in hot water to make a mild, organic repellent spray. Spray this on the affected foliage in the early morning or late afternoon.

insectsandorganicgardening.com.au

Pauline says 1 cup of fresh leaves and flowers, steeped in 1L of boiling water until cool. Use in a spray bottle. This will kill good insects as well. It is also a short lived pesticide.

Creating Your Homemade Rhubarb Leaf Pesticide

The process of turning rhubarb leaves into a potent pesticide is straightforward. Here's your step-by-step guide:

Ingredients:

A handful of rhubarb leaves

1 liter of water

Soap (optional)

Procedure:

Begin by chopping a handful of rhubarb leaves and place them in a large pot.

Add a liter of water to the pot and bring the mixture to a boil. Let it simmer for about 20-30 minutes.

After boiling, remove the pot from the heat and allow the solution to cool down completely.

Once cool, strain the liquid to remove all leaf particles.

For added effectiveness, consider adding a few drops of soap to the solution. The soap acts as a surfactant, which helps the solution adhere to the plants and insects.

Pour your solution into a spray bottle, and it's ready to use!

Precautions and Use

Before spraying your entire plant with the rhubarb leaf solution, always conduct a patch test. Spray a small area of the plant and wait for 24 hours to observe if there are any adverse reactions. If there are no signs of damage, you can proceed with spraying the entire plant.

This homemade rhubarb leaf pesticide can help repel several pests, including aphids, spider mites, and some types of beetles and caterpillars. Remember, though, that results may vary based on the species and environmental factors.

While the DIY rhubarb leaf pesticide is a traditional and natural approach, bear in mind it might not be as potent as commercial pesticides. Therefore, diligent monitoring of your plant's health is vital.

Conclusion

Rhubarb leaf pesticide is a natural, easy-to-make solution for those annoying garden pests. It's an age-old trick passed down through generations of gardeners and can be an effective part of an organic gardening toolkit. However, like any tool, it's crucial to use it wisely and observe your plants' reactions closely. Happy gardening!

<https://www.broughpestcontrol.co.uk/pest-top-tips/diy-rhubarb-leaf-pesticide-a-natural-solution-for-a-bug-free-garden/#:~:text=Creating%20Your%20Homemade,for%20other%20advice>

What seeds to plant in July

Fruit and Veg	Herbs	Flowers
 Onion Seeds <i>Direct or transplant, ready in 60-230 days.</i>	 Chervil <i>Direct or transplant, ready in 60-70 days.</i>	 Viola <i>Transplanted, flowers in 110-120 days.</i>
 Spinach <i>Direct sow, ready in 50-100 days.</i>	 Garlic <i>Direct sow, ready in 200-300 days.</i>	 Bearded Iris <i>Direct or transplant, flowers in 60-90 days.</i>
 Radish <i>Direct sow, ready in 40-60 days.</i>	 Shallots <i>Direct sow, ready in 120 days.</i>	 Anemone Corms <i>Direct sow, flowers in 90-110 days.</i>

<https://neutrog.com.au/seasons/winter/>

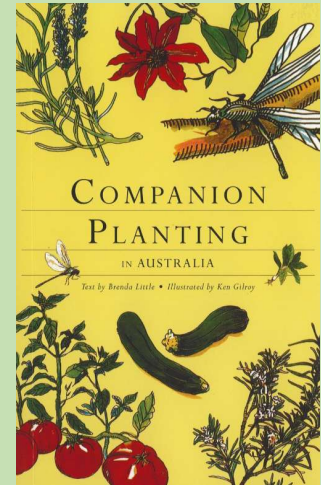
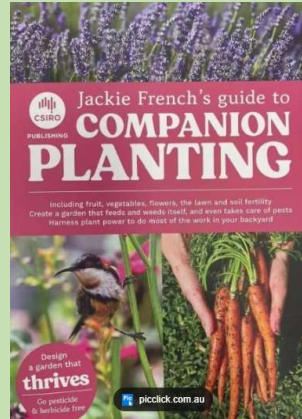
From My Bookshelf - July 2026

Jackie French's guide to companion planting in Australia and New Zealand. 1991 Companion planting in Australia. Brenda Little. 2008

As you can see I've had these two books for quite some time and they are very well used!. Every gardener should have at least one book on companion planting as they provide invaluable information and help you to avoid costly mistakes. In my early days of gardening I planted Rue in my herb patch and then watched most of the plants around it die. Sometimes, as Jackie French says, you should grow some plants in pots and move the pots around to where they might be needed. Jackie gives this invaluable information too: " Most herbs have strongly scented, insect repelling foliage. But be careful, as they may also inhibit plants growing near their dripline." Not all herbs will grow harmoniously together either.

Do you often wonder why they advertise potato bags so much? Yes they are great for space saving but when you also realise that potatoes do not grow well near "apple trees, cherry trees, cucumbers, pumpkin, sunflowers, tomatoes, and raspberry canes" (Little, p.62) you may not have a lot of space left in your Vegetable garden! Even our most beautiful flowers benefit from some good companions. Roses benefit from a clove of garlic being planted with it, and parsley, too, is helpful for warding off the dreaded aphid.

When you delve into the world of companion planting it makes such a lot of sense when you hear gardeners like Craig Castree talk about how important biodiversity is in your garden. Next time you plant something, even if it's in a pot, think about the plants around it and what it likes to be near.



Hello Gardeners All

We have passed the shortest day of this year and we all know how chilly it's been. Not thinking of nor doing the garden is easy! Has anyone else noticed how green some of the parks are with all the rain and cooler weather? Ruffy Park is the colour one sees of the UK countryside on TV!

In spite of the chill I have transplanted some cauliflower and broccolini seedlings I grew from seed. Also more Coles Dwarf broad beans are in as the last lot mostly failed due to soil being too wet. All the greens (celtuce, lettuce, silverbeet, carrot tops, peas & herbs) are very slowly doing their stuff. I'm hoping the broad bean seeds grow even with the coming wet week.

It's pruning time for any fruit trees and shrubs which need shaping. Figs and grapes always prune best in winter as both grow fruit on new growth. Citrus are ripe now. We are picking Imperial Mandarin and Washington Navel Oranges. My Eureka Lemon is not ready but it was pruned hard last year. Stone fruit were best pruned back in summer when crops finished.

The Red Czar Camelia has flowers blooming then dropping not too long later. The early Pink Sananquas finished weeks ago. Some Sylvia's bloom at this time of year as my Hotlips still has a flower even though pruned recently. The Pineapple Sage (makes a delicious herbal tea) also has its red flower stalks.

Happy Gardening, Pauline



Queen bee in the centre (long body)



Winter Beekeeping: How the Hive Survives

Winter is one of the most remarkable times in the life of a honey bee colony. While many insects become dormant or die off, honey bees work together as a superorganism to keep the colony alive until spring.

As temperatures drop, the queen dramatically reduces or even stops laying eggs. The colony forms a tight winter cluster around the queen, with worker bees generating heat by vibrating their flight muscles. Bees on the outside of the cluster continually rotate with those in the warmer centre, ensuring no individual bee becomes too cold.

This remarkable teamwork keeps the core of the cluster at around 20–35°C, depending on whether brood is present, even when outside temperatures are close to freezing.

To fuel this heat production, the colony relies on the honey it stored during the warmer months. During winter, bees avoid unnecessary flights, conserving both energy and precious food reserves until flowers become plentiful again.

However, prolonged periods of unusually warm winter weather can disrupt this natural rhythm. Warm temperatures encourage bees to leave the hive more frequently, increasing their activity and energy use. The queen may also begin laying brood earlier than normal, requiring the colony to maintain a higher internal temperature and consume even more honey.

If warm weather is followed by a return to cold conditions, colonies can be caught with growing brood, depleted food stores, and fewer resources available to sustain themselves. In areas where flowering plants have not yet begun producing nectar and pollen, bees may burn through their winter reserves well before spring arrives.

For beekeepers, winter is a time of observation rather than intervention. Regularly checking that colonies have adequate food stores, protecting hives from excessive wind and moisture, and avoiding unnecessary disturbance gives bees the best chance of emerging healthy and strong when spring finally arrives.

A healthy colony's ability to survive winter is a testament to the extraordinary cooperation of thousands of individual bees, each contributing to the warmth and survival of the hive until the seasons change.

DGC Life Members

Gerda van der Peet
Doug Brewer
Gayle McCann
Ted Page

Joanne Driver
Elsie Carter
Bev Turner
Franziska Kung



Hello Gardeners

As you may know, the garden light show called Lightscape is currently on at the Melbourne Botanic garden. This will be on until the 2nd August and costs \$36 to \$46 depending on the time. Most of you have probably seen this garden before, but Lightscape has transformed the garden into an absolutely stunning light show. Walking through the garden is done along illuminated pathways with light installations, music and artworks. Entrance is from the Observatory gate, Birdwood Ave. Tickets are timed and can be purchased through Ticketek. - Ron Thomson



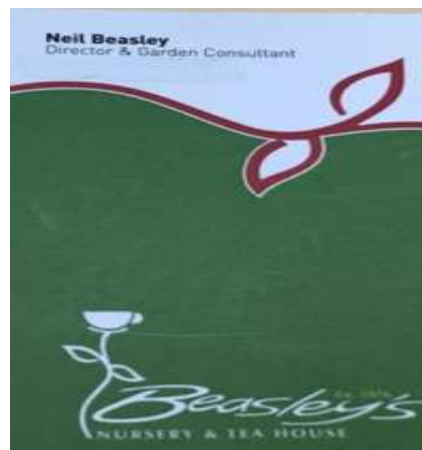


The Ryset Catalogue can be found online:

<https://ryset.com>



The Club receives wholesale prices which means discounts of up to 60-70%



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Let them know you are a member of DGC and appreciate how they help us.